Photoshop

Fitting Into A New Size

There are many situations where you'll need to get an image to fit into a specifically sized space. If you've been trying to resize graphics and they've ended up squished horizontally or vertically, this tip should help you out and keep your images from being digitally abused.

The size of our example image is 584 pixels high by 400 pixels wide. We need to resize the image so that the final size is 200 pixels high by 300 pixels wide.

To find the size of your image, select **Image > Image Size** from the Photoshop menu bar. This dialog box gives you the width, height and resolution of your image. You'll see a checkbox next to the word 'Proportions'. (Note: in Photoshop 4 and 5, this checkbox is labelled Constrain Proportions.) Don't uncheck that checkbox. Your image will be squished if you do.

Let's uncheck that 'Proportions' checkbox, and change the width to 300 and the height to 200 pixels, and take a look at the result.

Use [Ctrl] + [Z] to undo the damage, and select **Image > Image Size** again. Leave the 'Proportions' checkbox checked. You want to change only one dimension. Photoshop will then do the math for you and figure out how big the other dimension needs to be in order to retain the correct proportions for your image.

Which dimension do you change? Select the dimension that will need to change the most. In this example, we're changing an image that is 400w x 584h to 300w x 200h. The height dimension in this example needs to change the most, so we'll change the height from 584 to 200.

Photoshop scales the width size proportionately, making the image 137 pixels wide.

Now you'll need to change the width of the image. You don't want to use **Image > Image Size** for this. Instead, we'll use the **Image > Canvas Size** function.

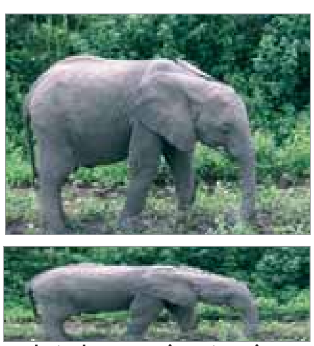
What the Canvas Size does is add pixels to your image, and it fills them with whatever background colour you selected.

Canvas Size changes the size of your image by adding to it, leaving the original image unchanged. The Image Size command changes the size of your image by anti-aliasing it.

Change the width number from 137 pixels to 200 pixels.

The Placement graphic gives you a choice of where the extra pixels will go: to the left, to the right of your image, or on either side of your image. We've left the original image centred, which is the default.

In our final image, we selected white as the background colour, so that is what the extra space, added on either side of the image by the Canvas command, was filled with.



A Photoshop experiment: resize the image above without keeping the 'Proportions' checkbox checked

The correct way to resize an image: using the 'Canvas Size' option

Making Icons With Bevelled Edges

Start out with your file the size you want your finished icon to be—we've used 40 x 40 pixels. Windows standard icons are generally 32 x 32.

The first method of making an icon is the standard toolbar-icon look that many software programs have, and can actually be done in Windows Paintbrush, PaintShop Pro, or any simple basic paint program.

Bucket fill the image with your background colour, which is usually light grey. Draw a one-pixel black border all the way around the icon. (Use the pencil tool with the smallest brush setting. Hold down [Shift] as you draw your line to constrain the pencil to a straight line).

Then, on the bottom and right sides of your icon, inside the black border, draw a darker grey line two pixels wide. On the left and top of the icon, draw a two-pixel white line. At the corners where the grey and white lines meet, stair-step the pixels so they form a 45-degree angle.

The second method can be used to create a bevelled edge not just for icons, but you can also use this to create bevelled edges for photos or scans as well.

First paste in your photo or texture whatever you'll be using as a background in a file the same size as your finished icon. Open your layers palette and add a layer.

On the second layer, draw a two or three pixel border in dark grey on the bottom and left sides of your file. On the top and right sides, draw a two or three pixel white border. Make sure that your corners where the grey and white meet are 45-degree angles. Now, drag the transparency slider at the top of the layers palette until it looks right. You can save this layered file as a .psd file to use later as a template for future icons.

Create Custom Brushes In Photoshop

You can create custom brushes in Photoshop. Open a new file, and make sure the 'Brush Palette' is open on screen.

You can create a brush up to 999 by 999 by pixels, which would be the digital equivalent of painting with a mop.

You'll want to keep your brushes on the smaller side, especially if you will be using them to create Web graphics.

For this example, we opened a small file, 100 pixels by 100 pixels, and selected **Filter > Add Noise**, using the Monochrome setting. We repeated the Noise filter ([Ctrl] +[F]) several times.

You'll find that brushes with soft edges are much more useful than brushes with hard edges.

To soften the edges of the brush, select an area of the image (about a quarter of the way in from all of the edges), then go to **Select > Feather**, then **Select > Inverse**. Fill the selected area with white.

Select the area of the image that you want to use as a brush. Next, from the flyout menu from the Brush Palette, select 'Define Brush'.

A new icon will appear on the brush palette for your new brush. You can save your new set of brushes by selecting 'Save Brushes' from the palette.

It helps to add to the default brush palette, rather than create an entirely new one. Also, it helps to test out the brush before you save it.

You can always delete a brush from the palette by selecting the icon for the brush, then selecting 'Delete Brush' from the flyout menu on the Brush Palette.

You can use the Brush Options on that same flyout menu to set the way the brush tracks.

Moreover, the default setting is 25—that is a percentage of the size of the brush, so the brush shape will repeat that often (depending on your settings in the Options palette). ⊠